

**Lesson 24:** “Be Not Deceived, but Continue in Steadfastness” (See L24 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

**Purpose:** To help us understand how we can avoid deception and apostasy.

*A pint of cream                      A misspelled name                      No available seating at the Kirtland Temple dedication*

**1. We should recognize the deceptions of Satan that can lead us into apostasy?**

- D&C 50:2-3; 2 Nephi 2:18, 27

The dashboard in our cars: speedometer, temperature gauge, fuel gauge, oil pressure light, and engine check light, etc.

*A. Not recognizing the prophet as the source of revelation for the Church*

- D&C 28; 43:1-7. †1. Joseph Smith

*Lesson Manual:* In 1830, Hiram Page, one of the Eight Witnesses to the Book of Mormon, possessed a stone through which he claimed to receive revelations about the building of Zion and the order of the Church. Oliver Cowdery, the Whitmers, and others believed these claims.... The Prophet prayed about the matter and received a revelation ... that only the President of the Church has the right to receive revelations for the Church (D&C 28). The Lord instructed Oliver Cowdery to tell Hiram Page that the revelations that came through the stone were from Satan (D&C 28:11). After hearing the Lord’s instructions, “Brother Page, as well as the whole Church who were present, renounced the said stone, and all things connected therewith.” (*History of the Church*, 1:115) †2. Parley P. Pratt

*B. Pride* †3. A pint of cream

President Gordon B. Hinckley: “What a very small and trivial thing—a little cream over which two women quarreled. But it led to, or at least was a factor in, Governor Boggs’ cruel exterminating order which drove the Saints from the state of Missouri, with all the terrible suffering and consequent death that followed. The man who should have settled this little quarrel, but who, rather pursued it, ... lost his standing in the Church. He lost his testimony of the gospel.” (*Ensign*, May 1984, 83)

†4. Thomas B. Marsh returned

What does the Lord promise to those who humble themselves before Him? (D&C 112:2-3, 10)

*C. Being critical of leaders’ imperfections* †5. A misspelled name

How does being critical of our Church leaders make us more susceptible to deception?

*D. Being offended* †6. No available seating at the Kirtland Temple dedication

How can we overcome feelings of being offended?

- D&C 64:8-11; 82:1.

*E. Rationalizing disobedience*

How is rationalization a form of deception? Why is this dangerous?

†7. William C. Beardall

How can we recognize and overcome rationalization?

*F. Accepting the false teachings of the world*

**2. We can remain valiant in our testimonies and avoid deception.**

Heber J. Grant: “I have never known a person, man or woman, who attended his meetings, and partook of the spirit and inspiration that are present in the meetings of true, faithful Latter-day Saints, who has ever apostatized.” (*Gospel Standards*, 42)

What can we do to keep ourselves from being deceived and led into apostasy?

*We can know clearly whom the Lord has called to lead the Church*

*We should study the scriptures and doctrines of the Church*

- Joseph Smith—Matthew 1:37. “And whoso treasureth up my word, shall not be deceived”.

*We should recognize that the things of God will always edify us*

*We should apply the Lord’s pattern for protecting ourselves from being deceived*

†8. Elder Melvin J. Ballard: †9. President Spencer W. Kimball †10. President Joseph Fielding Smith

Next Week: L25: “Priesthood: The Power of Godliness” See L25 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325.](#)) † •

†1. **Joseph Smith:** “I will inform you that it is contrary to the economy of God for any member of the Church, or any one, to receive instructions for those in authority, higher than themselves ... for the fundamental principles, government, and doctrine of the Church are vested in the keys of the kingdom.” (*History of the Church*, 1:338)

†2. **Parley P. Pratt after he returned to Kirtland from his mission to Missouri and a short mission to the Shakers and ministered to the branches of the Church:** “As I went forth among the different branches, some very strange spiritual operations were manifested, which were disgusting, rather than edifying. Some persons would seem to swoon away, and make unseemly gestures, and be drawn or disfigured in their countenances. Others would fall into ecstasies, and be drawn into contortions, cramp, fits, etc. Others would seem to have visions and revelations, which were not edifying, and which were not congenial to the doctrine and spirit of the gospel. In short, a false and lying spirit seemed to be creeping into the Church.” ...

“Feeling our weakness and inexperience, and lest we should err in judgment concerning these spiritual phenomena, myself, John Murdock, and several other Elders, went to Joseph Smith, and asked him to inquire of the Lord concerning these spirits or manifestations. After we had joined in prayer in his translating room, he dictated in our presence the following revelation [D&C 50].” (*Autobiography of Parley P. Pratt*, 48)

†3. **A pint of cream:** “While living in Far West, Missouri, Sister Marsh and Sister Harris decided to exchange milk so they could each make a larger cheese than they otherwise could. They agreed to send each other both the milk and the cream from their cows. But Sister Marsh saved a pint of cream from each cow and sent Sister Harris the milk without the cream.

“A quarrel arose, and the matter was referred to the bishop. When he determined that Sister Marsh had violated her agreement, she and her husband were upset and appealed the matter to the high council and then to the First Presidency. Each council approved the original decision that Sister Marsh had been in error.

“Thomas B. Marsh declared that he would sustain the character of his wife. Soon afterward, he turned against the Church and went before a government official to declare that the Latter-day Saints were hostile toward the state of Missouri. (*Lesson Manual*, 135; See George A. Smith, in *Journal of Discourses*, 3:283-84)

†4. **Thomas B. Marsh returned:** “After 19 years of darkness and bitterness, Thomas B. Marsh painfully made his way to the Salt Lake Valley and asked Brigham Young to forgive him and permit his rebaptism in the Church. He wrote to Heber C. Kimball, First Counselor in the First Presidency: “I began to awake to a sense of my situation; ... I know that I have sinned against Heaven and in thy sight.” He then described the lesson he had learned: “The Lord could get along very well without me and He has lost nothing by my falling out of the ranks; But O what have I lost?! Riches, greater riches than all this world or many planets like this could afford.” (*Lesson Manual*, 135-36; Thomas B. Marsh’s words quoted by James E. Faust, “The Prophetic Voice,” *Ensign*, May 1996, 7)

†5. **A misspelled name:** “Simonds Ryder was converted to the Church in 1831. Later he received a letter signed by the Prophet Joseph Smith and Sidney Rigdon, informing that it was the Lord’s will, made manifest by the Spirit, that he preach the gospel. Both in the letter he received and in the official commission to preach, his name was spelled *Rider* instead of *Ryder*. Simonds Ryder ‘thought if the “Spirit” through he had been called to preach could err in the matter of spelling his name, it might have erred in calling him to the ministry as well; or, in other words, he was led to doubt if he were called at all by the Spirit of God, because of the error in spelling his name!’” (*History of the Church*, 1:261) Simonds Ryder later apostatized from the Church.

†6. **No available seating at the Kirtland Temple dedication:** “When the Kirtland Temple was completed, many Saints gathered for the dedication. The seats in the temple filled quickly, and many people were allowed to stand, but still not everyone could be accommodated inside the building. Elder Frazier Eaton, who had given \$700 for the building of the temple, arrived after it had been filled, so he was not allowed inside for the dedication. The dedication was repeated the next day for those who could not be accommodated the first day, but this did not satisfy Frazier Eaton, and he apostatized.” (*Lesson Manual*, 136; See George A. Smith, in *Journal of Discourses*, 11:9)

#### **Recommended Reading:**

1. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Be Not Deceived](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 2004.
2. Elder Gordon B. Hinckley, “[Be Not Deceived](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1983.

## Further Enrichment:

†7. **William C. Beardall:** “To demonstrate the absolute danger in rationalizing disobedience, I share an incident that occurred during the time while I was on my mission. I learned of this incident at a zone conference when the mission president read a letter from one of the missionaries involved. In this letter, the former missionary said that he and his companion started to break some of the mission rules. They slept in later than 6:30 AM because they were tired. They did not think there was anything wrong with listening to a little non-church music. Bit by bit their disobedience of mission rules increased. By doing so, the spirit fled. All of this led to an incident one evening. The results of this increasing disobedience and rationalization eventually led to their being dishonorably sent home from their missions and their excommunication.” (Gospel Doctrine Class: [D&C L24](#))

†8. **Elder Melvin J. Ballard:** “No man goes away from this Church and becomes an apostate in a week, nor in a month. It is a slow process. The one thing that would make for the safety of every man and woman would be to appear at the sacrament table every Sabbath day. We would not get very far away in a week—not so far away that, by the process of self-investigation, we could not rectify the wrongs we may have done. If we should refrain from partaking of the sacrament, condemned by ourselves as unworthy to receive these emblems, we could not endure that long, and we would soon, I am sure, have the spirit of repentance. The road to the sacrament table is the path of safety for Latter-day Saints.” (quoted in *Doctrinal Commentary on the Book of Mormon*, 4:121)

†9. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “In my experience, few people have ever lost their peace, their spirituality, their testimony when they kept close to the Lord in their prayers, to the Church in their activities, to the people of the Church in their fellowship. Seldom does one become seriously doubtful or faithless who continues to read the Holy Scriptures and keep his life clean. ‘Put on the whole armour of God,’ as Paul admonished. With this divine influence and protection, we may be able to discern the adversary’s deceptions in whatever appealing words and rationalizations and we may be ‘able to withstand the evil day, and having done all, to stand’.” (*Faith Precedes the Miracle*, 218)

†10. **President Joseph Fielding Smith:** “Now, if you understand the gospel of Jesus Christ, it will make you free. If your softball, your volleyball, your basketball, your foot racing, your dancing, your other entertainments are devoid of the Spirit of the Lord, they will be of no value to you. Let everything be done in the spirit of prayer and in faith. I think that is the case—maybe it is unnecessary for me to say it—but so let it be. Do everything with an eye single unto the glory of God, and let us teach to build up and strengthen ourselves and The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints.

“Search the scriptures that you may not be deceived by false theories and practices and doctrines so prevalent in the world today. (“[Be Not Deceived](#),” *New Era*, Mar. 2011.)

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